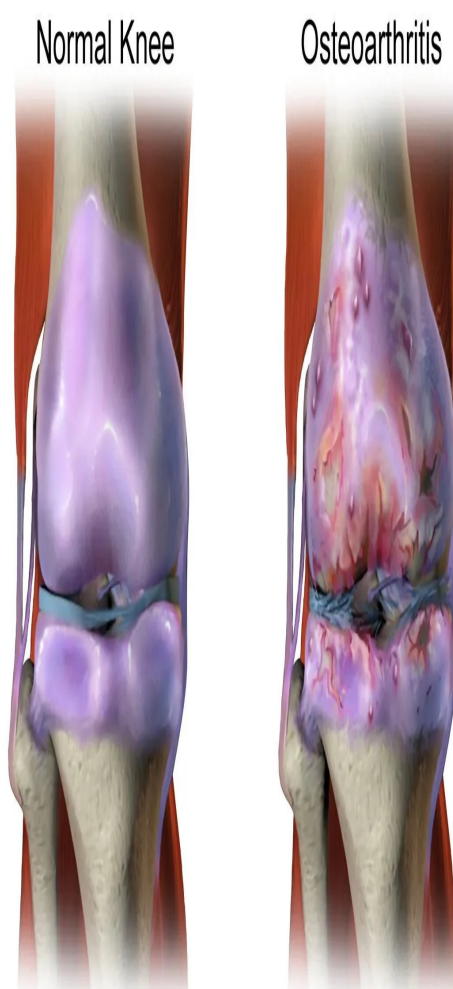


Arthritis and Sleep: How to Get a Better Night's Rest

Pain and poor sleep fuel each other. Break the cycle with these evidence-based sleep strategies designed for people with arthritis.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Advisory Panel** (HCPC-registered physiotherapy & rheumatology nursing input) · 2026-03-08 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Arthritis and Sleep



Openly licensed image via Openverse

Up to **80%** of people with arthritis report sleep difficulties, according to Arthritis Research UK. The relationship between pain and sleep is bidirectional: pain disrupts sleep, and poor sleep amplifies pain sensitivity — creating a cycle that can feel impossible to break.

Why Arthritis Disrupts Sleep

- **Nocturnal pain:** Joint stiffness often peaks during periods of inactivity. Lying still for hours can increase discomfort.
- **Inflammation timing:** Cortisol (which suppresses inflammation) drops to its lowest levels around midnight to 4am, allowing inflammatory cytokines to rise.
- **Medication side effects:** Some arthritis drugs (particularly steroids) can cause insomnia if taken late in the day.
- **Anxiety and depression:** Common in arthritis, these conditions independently disrupt sleep architecture.

Sleep Hygiene Fundamentals



Openly licensed image via Openverse

****1. Consistent schedule**** Go to bed and wake up at the same time daily — even on weekends. This anchors your circadian rhythm and improves sleep quality within 2–3 weeks.

****2. Temperature**** Keep your bedroom at 16–18°C. Your body needs to drop its core temperature to initiate sleep. However, keep joints warm — thermal sleepwear or joint-specific warmers can help.

****3. Screen curfew**** Blue light from phones and tablets suppresses melatonin production. Stop screens 60 minutes before bed. If you must use a device, enable night mode.

****4. Caffeine cut-off**** Caffeine has a half-life of 5–6 hours. Your last cup should be no later than 2pm.



Openly licensed image via Openverse

Joint-Specific Sleep Strategies

Knee arthritis: - Place a pillow between your knees when side-sleeping to maintain hip alignment - Avoid sleeping with knees fully bent — this shortens the hamstrings and increases morning stiffness

Hip arthritis: - Sleep on the unaffected side with a pillow between the knees - A memory foam mattress topper can reduce pressure points - Avoid sleeping on your front — this forces the hip into extension and rotation

Hand arthritis: - Wear resting splints overnight if recommended by your occupational therapist - Keep hands elevated on a pillow to reduce morning swelling

Spine/back arthritis: - A medium-firm mattress is generally best (BMJ study, 2003) - Place a pillow under your knees when sleeping on your back - Avoid the foetal position with a very curved spine

Before-Bed Routine for Arthritis

A calming 30-minute routine can significantly improve sleep: 1. **Warm bath or shower** (raises then drops body temperature, promoting drowsiness) 2. **Gentle stretches** (5 minutes of range-of-motion exercises) 3. **Apply topical pain relief** (e.g., Voltarol gel to troublesome joints) 4. **Relaxation technique** (progressive muscle relaxation, guided meditation, or breathing exercises)

When to Seek Help

If you've tried these strategies for 4+ weeks without improvement, speak to your GP about: - **Sleep study referral** — to rule out sleep apnoea (more common in people with arthritis, especially those who are overweight) - **Cognitive Behavioural Therapy for Insomnia (CBT-I)** — recommended by NICE as first-line treatment, available through NHS Talking Therapies - **Medication review** — timing adjustments may help

Key Takeaway

Improving sleep is one of the most impactful things you can do for your arthritis. Better sleep means lower pain sensitivity, less inflammation, and more energy for the exercises and activities that keep your joints healthy.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about arthritis and sleep: how to get a better night's rest?

Short answer: Up to 80% of people with arthritis report sleep difficulties. Improving sleep involves maintaining a consistent schedule, keeping the bedroom cool (16–18°C), avoiding screens an hour before bed, and stopping caffeine by 2pm. Joint-specific strategies include using pillows for alignment, applying topical pain relief, and gentle stretching. A warm bath before bed can also aid sleep. If issues persist after four weeks, consult a GP.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Versus Arthritis: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis UK · livingwitharthritis.org.uk